Relations really took a dip when Japanese policymakers of that period decided to lead the charge against India in international forums.

The resulting freeze in the relationship ended up providing an opportunity for both nations to introspect on its value. And from that exercise emerged a new phase of our bilateral ties. Just as President Clinton's visit marked the breakthrough in one relationship, that of PM Yoshiro Mori did in the other. And interestingly, while President George W. Bush took it to a higher level in regard to the US, PM Shinzo Abe did so even more personally in respect of Japan. His famous 'The Confluence of Two Seas' speech to the Indian Parliament in 2007 was not only a turning point for the bilateral relationship but an early vision of what emerged as the Indo-Pacific. The context for that unfolding is also worth recalling.

A decade-and-a-half ago, Japan, too, was contemplating an increasingly uncertain external environment that required it to contemplate greater responsibilities. Given its complex history, this naturally was accompanied by an involved domestic debate. A society with a broader agenda and taking a greater interest in world affairs will understandably look for more partners. India, no longer distanced by the Cold War, offered obvious attraction. Some of this was a regional convergence, some a shared quest for better UN representation and some a natural empathy of democratic societies. So here, too, the bilateral wheels began to move on their own logic. As they gathered greater traction, vistas of cooperation also opened up.

Between India and Japan now, the political messaging is strong, underlined by a practice of annual summits since 2006. Despite changes in administrations on both ends, the pace of cooperation has not slackened. As in the case of the US, this continuity is the strongest proof of structural change. The official description of the relationship has continuously grown, titled most recently in 2014 as a Special Strategic and Global Partnership. Trade may have remained limited despite a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) in 2011, but Japanese investments in India have expanded both in sectors and volume. Japan ranks fifth as a source of investment and more ambitious goals were set during PM Fumio Kishida's visit in 2022.

The economic partnership as a whole has intensified, whether we consider currency swaps or development assistance. In fact, the ODA has more than doubled in the last decade itself, with disbursement touching